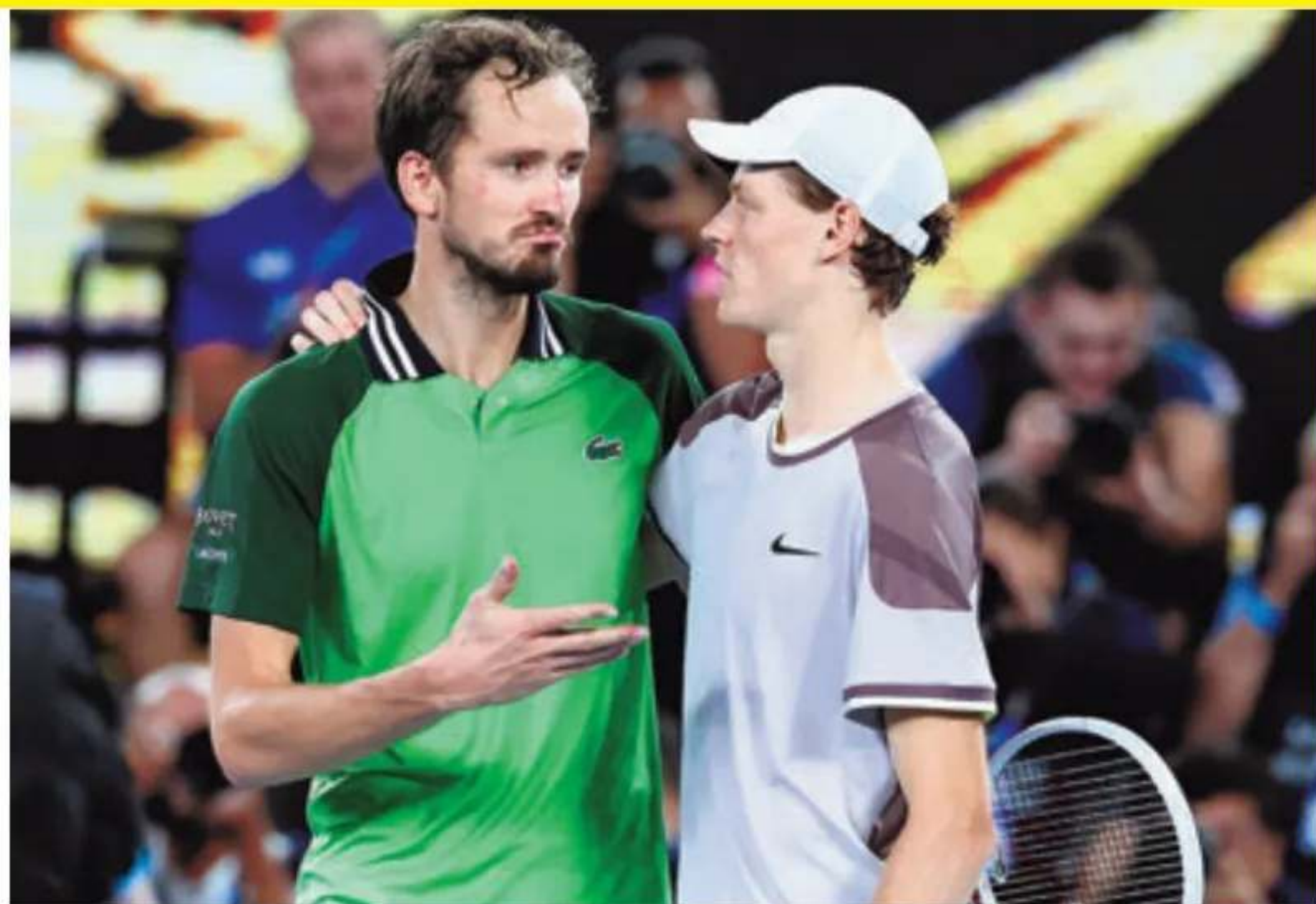




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One for the record books: Sinner became the first Italian man to capture a Grand Slam singles title since Adriano Panatta won the 1976 French Open and the youngest men's AO champion since Novak Djokovic in 2008. GETTYIMAGES

Paul Fein

A woman in the crowd kissed the carrot she grasped for good luck. Like Jannik Sinner's 'carota' fans in Italy and his burgeoning legion of devotees around the world, she sensed victory. Sinner led 5-3, 30-all in the deciding set of the Australian Open final. But Daniil Medvedev, a tenacious competitor, had taken the last two points.

Could Medvedev somehow come back just as Sinner had after losing the first two sets? The preternaturally calm Italian attacked with a forehand that the tired Medvedev barely reached and couldn't return. 5-3, 40-30 championship point. **With the poise of a veteran champion, 22-year-old Sinner moved his opponent around the court to set up his signature shot. Then he unleashed a rocket forehand down the line for his first Grand Slam title.**

If Sinner's fans were nervous wrecks during pivotal points in the 3-6, 3-6, 6-4, 6-4, 6-3 final, especially during the last game, their hero wasn't. "I like to dance in the pressure storm," he said. "I like it, because that's where, most of the time, I bring out my best tennis."

Perhaps the gangly strawberry blonde's remarkable sangfroid comes from Sexton, a small town in the German-speaking region of Italy just seven miles from the Austrian border. There he was a standout skier — nicknamed 'Jan the Fox' — until he switched to tennis at 13. His father worked as a chef in a ski lodge, while his mother was a waitress. Jannik likes to describe himself as "humble."

His surname is comically ironic because he's likable and low-key off the court and well-behaved and fair on it. "Jannik is an